

What are the alternatives to Charleroi?

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Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By JORDYN DAHL with TOMMASO LECCA and MARTINA SAPIO SNEAK PEEK — As Belgium's s

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure.

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SNEAK PEEK

— As Belgium's second-busiest airport makes plans to shut down for more than two months in 2028, nearby airports could benefit from flights usually operated from Charleroi.

— Job cuts at Europe's automakers continue as the continent's brands reveal financial losses for first half of the year.

— Record-low water levels in the Danube reveal how exposed Europe's inland shipping corridors are to heat-driven drought.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

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DRIVING THE DAY

WHAT THE CHARLEROI AIRPORT CLOSURE MEANS FOR PASSENGERS: In just two years, Charleroi airport will shut from Aug. 16 to Oct. 31 — an 11-week closure that will affect tens of thousands of passengers every day. Aviation experts say airlines — above all Ryanair, which accounts for around 85 percent of Charleroi's flights — will struggle to find alternative airports offering similarly low charges and operating costs.

Latest from airlines: Air Corsica — which serves the Corsican towns of Ajaccio, Bastia, Calvi and Figari from Charleroi— had no comment on contingency plans or possible alternate airports. Ryanair and Wizz Air, Charleroi's two biggest customers, are also silent on the closure.

You'll miss it: "Charleroi has a rather unique position ... it combines a large catchment area with a strongly developed low-cost network and an airport operation specifically designed around that model," said Wouter Dewulf, an air transport economist at the University of Antwerp. "There is no directly comparable low-cost airport in the immediate vicinity that can reproduce this network, cost base and market position."

Yes, but: Airlines will have to redeploy some aircraft based at Charleroi, reduce frequency and suspend some routes during the closure, Dewulf said. "A limited number of strategically important or particularly profitable routes could temporarily move to [Zaventem's] Brussels Airport," he said. However, Belgium's main hub "cannot simply absorb the entire Charleroi operation while maintaining the same very low fares," Dewulf added, pointing to constraints including terminal capacity, slots, aircraft parking, ground handling and security.

No easy option among Belgium's smaller airports: Asked about Ostend-Bruges and Antwerp airports, Dewulf said the former is less attractive because of its location, while the latter faces runway, terminal and operational constraints. "Neither airport could realistically replace Charleroi on a large scale."

From cargo to passengers? Another option could be Liège Airport, the EU's fifth-largest cargo airport. "Liège is technically a possibility ... but its organization and business model are overwhelmingly focused on cargo," Dewulf told Tommaso, adding that the airport would need to expand its passenger-handling capabilities to become part of the solution.

Looking beyond Belgium, Dewulf said Lille "would probably be one of the most logical alternatives for passengers from Hainaut and northern France." Other possible options include Luxembourg, Maastricht Aachen, Eindhoven, Weeze, Cologne-Bonn and Paris-Beauvais, he added.

CARS

AUTOMAKERS CONTINUE TO SLASH JOBS: BMW is presenting its half-year earnings today less than 24 hours after reports that it is laying off 8,000 workers by the end of 2027. A spokesperson told POLITICO the cuts will be focused on administrative and R&D roles. The luxury automaker joins its fellow German brands in looking to cut costs as sales decline and competition continues to ramp up in China.

Reminder: BMW downgraded its financial projection for the year in June, telling investors its margins will be in the 1 percent to 3 percent range, down from its initial 4 percent to 6 percent projection. The main reason for the downturn is a fall in sales in China where BMW is facing stiff competition from domestic rivals.

In good company: Volkswagen, Mercedes and Porsche are all taking similar action. We will learn today whether Renault and Stellantis will follow suit as they both report their half-year earnings today alongside BMW.

Cost-cutting measures: Porsche opened its earnings call on Wednesday with an update on its cost-saving program that will include axing a further 5,000 jobs on top of the previously announced 4,000 jobs. "Products and innovations are a longer-term topic. Right now, our focus is primarily on costs," CEO Michael Leiters told investors.

OIL CRISIS COULD SPUR EV SALES: The energy crisis resulting from the war in Iran has the "potential to further accelerate changes" in the automotive sector, a new report out today from the International Energy Agency argues. Road transport accounts for nearly half of the world's oil consumption and rising fuel prices have pushed some consumers to look at electric vehicles. EV sales increased 35 percent worldwide from the first quarter to the second quarter of this year, the report says, while year-over-year sales grew 4 percent.

Policy shifts: Governments around the world are responding to the energy crisis with subsidies and lower import tariffs to encourage EV adoption. The biggest sales growth is happening in emerging markets like Latin America and Southeast Asia. (Catch up on our reporting from earlier this month on

the state of the car market in Thailand and what it means for European brands.)

Exports — a saving grace: Chinese automakers are taking advantage of the new EV support schemes. Their home market is contracting, causing consternation for both European automakers and domestic brands. Total car sales declined 20 percent year-over-year in the first half of 2026. In response, Chinese automakers are looking abroad, with overall car exports increasing 65 percent in the first half of 2026, according to the report. Chinese EV exports surged by more than 120 percent.

Not going away: Despite the Chinese numbers, the IEA expects global sales to be 2 percent lower in 2026 as consumers contend with high prices and economic uncertainty. The bright spot is electric vehicles, which the IEA now estimates will account for 29 percent of car sales this year. Global EV sales are expected to increase 10 percent this year compared to 2025.

MARITIME

THE SHALLOW DANUBE: The Danube River in Romania has the lowest water levels in 30 years, showing how exposed Europe's inland shipping corridors are to drought, just as Brussels is banking on rivers to carry more of the bloc's freight.

Upstream stress: The country's water agency clocked the Danube's entry flow at 1,700 cubic meters per second, against a July average of 4,700 — a drop steep enough to also restrict farmers' irrigation access, competing directly with navigation for what water remains.

Historical wounds: The drought is severe enough that centuries-old wrecks are resurfacing from the riverbed in Croatia and Serbia, while Germany's Rhine — Europe's busiest inland waterway — is forcing freight operators to sail with partial loads to avoid grounding.

Cargo capacity, halved: Serbia's fuel imports by barge are only 25 percent of their monthly target, with tankers forced to carry under half their normal cargo load — a preview of the kind of capacity crunch that could ripple through other Danube-dependent supply chains if levels don't recover before the fall.

Why it matters for Brussels: The Commission's NAIADES III action plan, proposed in 2021, is aimed at expanding inland waterway capacity. Inland waterways carry just 6 percent of EU freight today, and the plan aims to expand inland-waterway and short-sea shipping volumes by 25 percent by 2030 and by 50 percent by 2050. But it's unclear whether the current pace of hydrological investment is keeping up with increasingly frequent low-water events.

Knock-on to the grid: But the drought isn't just a shipping story. Romania's Nuclearelectrica shut down part of its Cernavodă plant as a "preventative measure" to protect cooling-pump equipment, warning a failure could mean repairs lasting up to a year.

CHINA LEAVES EUROPE IN ITS WAKE ON GREEN SHIPPING FUELS: China is producing 10 times more e-fuels for shipping than Europe despite having far fewer projects, according to a new analysis from green NGO Transport & Environment. That raises fresh concerns over the EU's ability to build a domestic market for clean maritime fuels.

Projects everywhere: T&E says Europe now has 69 e-fuel projects that could supply the shipping sector, but only six are operational. By contrast, China already has three operational projects producing around 700,000 tons of e-ammonia for shipping annually. According to T&E, Beijing's ability to commercialize projects more quickly risks allowing Chinese producers to dominate the emerging European market before domestic production scales up.

TRUCKS

ELECTRIC TRUCKS GAIN GROUND: Sales of electric trucks and buses continued to accelerate across Europe in the first half of 2026, with more than 14,300 new zero-emission vehicles registered — a 40 percent increase on the same period last year, according to data out today from the International Council on Clean Transportation.

PIT STOPS

Audi workers protested the potential closure of the German automaker's Neckarsulm plant. Reuters has more .

ITA Airways has started allowing dogs weighing up to 30 kilograms to travel in the cabin on selected domestic "Large Dog" scheduled flights, which begin operating on Aug. 3.

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

The EU's foreign subsidy rules are deterring Chinese firms. At what cost?

As it turns three, the Foreign Subsidies Regulation has changed corporate behavior. Whether Europe benefits is another question.

By Francesca Micheletti · Jul 30, 2026, 06:00 am Europe/Brussels CEST

Trump unveils Dulles airport overhaul: 'We're going to make it maybe the best.'

The revamp of the Washington-area airport is estimated to cost \$22 billion.

By Oriana Pawlyk · Jul 29, 2026, 11:00 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

BMW to cut 8,000 jobs by the end of 2027

German-based workers in administrative and research and development roles will be offered a severance program.

By Jordyn Dahl · Jul 29, 2026, 12:23 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

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